

# Nature Today

Grade 6 | 2-5 minutes | Notice - Explain - Revisit

## Learning goal

I can describe evidence, ask a question, and explain or revise one idea about a place.

## Before students arrive

- Choose one supplied image, a window view or a safe observation point. Read the caption, date, location and teacher note before making claims about the subject.
- Have the image bank and optional student journal ready. Provide a large image, a concise spoken/text description and response choices. School-supplied paper and pencils are enough.
- Say whether the image is local, from another place, or archival. Do not call an older photograph today's Surrey conditions.

## Run the routine

### 1 Notice | 30-60 seconds

Look closely or use the description. Name two details that the source supports. What do you wonder?

### 2 Explain | 45-90 seconds

Try one explanation using a specific detail. Separate what is observed from what is inferred. What could another explanation be?

### 3 Revisit | 30-60 seconds

Use the Revisit prompt to plan a next observation or compare with an earlier dated view. What evidence would help?

Finish with a brief share: say, draw, write, dictate or use AAC. Two-minute version: one detail, one tentative explanation, one next question. Five-minute version: add a buddy exchange or comparison and an evidence-based revision.

Model: 'I see three droplets on the leaf edge. I think the leaf is wet. I cannot tell from this photo whether the water is rain or dew.'

# The image menu

Use these as invitations to notice. The image bank supplies all three prompts and complete credits.

## 01 Leaves underfoot

Describe two differences between the leaves. What can you point to?

Teacher note: A photograph records one place and moment. Colour alone does not establish the date or cause of change. Compare repeated observations rather than assuming a fixed autumn timetable.

## 02 A leaf worth looking at

Follow the leaf edge with your eyes or a description. What shapes repeat?

Teacher note: Use the image source identification and the BC Tree Book together. Bigleaf maple has deeply cut lobes; colour by itself is not enough to identify a tree.

## 03 Patterns in a cone

Find one repeated shape and one detail that stands out.

Teacher note: The BC Tree Book describes three-pronged bracts on Douglas-fir cones. A cone on the ground does not prove it came from the nearest tree. Leave habitat materials in place.

## 04 Life on fallen wood

Describe where the mushrooms are growing. Avoid guessing their names.

Teacher note: Many fungi produce visible fruiting bodies, including in autumn. A single photograph cannot establish edibility or the whole decomposition process. Never taste or pick unknown fungi.

## 05 A tiny landscape

Zoom in. Describe the shapes and the surface supporting them.

Teacher note: Mosses are small non-vascular plants. Describe the image without inventing a species identification or measuring moisture by appearance alone. Do not scrape samples.

## 06 Moss or something else?

Describe the edge, colour and texture you can see or learn from the image description.

Teacher note: Lichens involve fungi and photosynthetic partners; they are not moss. One lichen sighting is not a stand-alone measure of air quality. The image source names this lichen; local look-alikes need checking.

## 07 Weather over the coast

Describe the sky, distant land and water. What is visible and what is hard to see?

Teacher note: A cloudy or misty view does not by itself prove rain is falling. Use the source description, then predict possible runoff near school. One still image does not measure flow speed or water quality.

## 08 A stream close to home

Describe two features beside or within the stream.

Teacher note: This is an archival Surrey image, not a current site report. Surrey explains that pollutants entering storm drains can reach waterways. Stay on designated viewing areas; do not enter streams.

# The image menu / continued

Use these as invitations to notice. The image bank supplies all three prompts and complete credits.

## 09 Salmon: look for evidence

What can you observe about the fish and its surroundings?

Teacher note: Surrey lists autumn salmon viewing opportunities, but dates and sightings vary by site, species and year. This historical photo does not confirm a run today. Never disturb fish or enter the stream.

## 10 A gathering of birds

Describe the birds and their spacing. Which actions can you actually see?

Teacher note: The photograph is from Reifel in Delta. It is a regional example, not proof of birds at school. Do not infer that every bird seen in autumn is migrating or that a pose reveals its intention.

## 11 A web holds clues

Trace or describe a repeating pattern. Where are the droplets?

Teacher note: Use “web with droplets” in student observations. Even when a source calls droplets dew, the visual evidence alone may not distinguish condensation from rain. Webs are not exclusive to autumn.

## 12 A fallen tree, a living place

Find evidence of plants growing on or near the fallen wood.

Teacher note: Down wood can provide habitat and support plant growth. Do not lift logs to find organisms. An observation can suggest a relationship without proving every cause.

## 13 Small life among leaves

Describe the animal and one feature of its surroundings.

Teacher note: This photo is an example of leaf-litter habitat. Do not assume the same snail species occurs locally. Leave animals and shelter undisturbed; no touching or collecting is needed.

## 14 Shapes that repeat

Describe a repeating shape along the frond.

Teacher note: Use the source label for the photographed plant. The task is evidence-based comparison, not unverified local identification. Seasonal change can be subtle in plants that remain green.

## 15 Many kinds of green

Find two contrasting shapes or colours in the forest view.

Teacher note: Different plants change in different ways. A broad forest photograph cannot reliably identify every tree. Record dates, viewpoint and conditions before comparing images.

## Return to the same place

Revisit one tree, view or image pair. Keep the date, approximate viewpoint and observation length consistent when possible. Record differences in weather or framing that could affect a comparison.

Ask: What stayed similar? What changed? What evidence supports that claim? What else would we need to observe? A different, supported interpretation can remain different.

# Grade 6 connections

Official British Columbia curriculum links. The strongest daily links are Science inquiry and ELA.

## Science 6

Primary connection: observation, inquiry questions, predictions, suitable records, patterns and explanations supported by evidence. Interpret the local environment and communicate in varied forms. This routine is an inquiry context; do not label biodiversity or ecosystems as the Grade 6 content unit.

## English Language Arts 6

Primary connection: interpret photographs as visual texts, make meaningful connections, exchange viewpoints and refine a concise explanation. Invite a response through speech, writing, drawing, dictation, a home language or AAC.

## Physical and Health Education 6

Optional walk connection: safe movement, leadership, healthy relationships and reflection on well-being. Seated or photo observation keeps the Science/ELA goal; it does not automatically meet the physical-activity competency. Plan appropriate movement separately.

## Career Education 6

Optional connection: explicitly practise inclusive collaboration, leadership and safety, set a learning goal or plan a small stewardship project. A photograph alone is not career exploration.

## Social Studies 6

Optional extension: investigate an actual green-space access or habitat-management issue; compare reliable sources and perspectives and propose an informed action. A walk alone is not a Social Studies inquiry.

Assess the thinking students demonstrate. Frequency, a curriculum label, completion of every box or an outdoor location does not establish learning by itself.

# A buddy neighbourhood observation

A short route, a seated stop, a window view and a dated photograph can all support observation and evidence.

## Plan the participation before the walk

- Privately invite support preferences. Preview the specific route's surface, slope, distance, crossings, rest places, washrooms, shelter and sounds. Check actual conditions and school procedures; no park label guarantees every route fits every learner.
- Offer equally valued ways to join: firm-surface route; sheltered seated stop; window observation; or teacher-supplied image/description. Keep peers connected across options. No family purchase, device, transport or home nature access is required.
- Bring school materials. Offer large print/zoom, high-contrast text, image descriptions, spoken and written directions, vocabulary supports, home languages, AAC, dictation and quiet response choices.

## Use roles that rotate

Observer chooses a detail; questioner asks what the evidence supports; recorder captures the idea in a chosen form. In a pair, combine questioner and recorder, then swap at the next stop. No student is permanently assigned as a helper. Offer independent or adult-supported participation.

## An 8-12 minute option

- Before leaving: name one observation goal, the agreed boundary, stop/return signal and participation choices.
- At one or two stops: notice two details, ask one question and record one idea; switch roles. Adults manage road, water and group safety.
- On return: each pair offers one detail and one question. Revisit a shared photo next time so every mode feeds the same class conversation.

Care for the place: observe without tasting, collecting unknown organisms, moving logs, entering streams or approaching nests. Follow current site notices and school procedures.

Surrey Nature Centre: [specific access information](#)

The site lists multiple surface types and slopes, seating, and a junior-size all-terrain chair loan. Check suitability and availability; this is not a verified class route.

# Salmon, streams and evidence

Use the supplied photo even when a trip or a live salmon sighting is not possible.

## Start with what is supplied

Show the salmon or stream image. Students record two visible details, one possible explanation and one question that the photograph cannot answer. Use journal page 5.

## A possible local connection

The City of Surrey describes October-November opportunities to see returning salmon; its Tynehead page lists October-December viewing. Species, site, year and water conditions affect what is visible. These are seasonal possibilities, not a forecast or a guarantee.

Choose a visit only after current site and school checks. Select an appropriate established viewing area and an equivalent photo/window/seated participation route. This pack does not verify trail conditions, transport, permissions, water levels or individual access.

## Keep explanations proportional to the evidence

- A still image can show fish shape, number within the frame, water and nearby habitat. It cannot establish the whole population, exact movement, water quality or a successful migration.
- Students may hypothesize a connection between rain, stream conditions and returning fish. Ask what dated observations or a reliable source would help evaluate it.
- No fish is a useful result too: record when and where you looked and what you could see. Do not conclude that a stream contains no fish.

## Try a care question

How could we help keep pollutants out of rainwater routes? Surrey's storm-drain information connects drains with local waterways. Use a safe photograph of a drain marker; do not send children into a road or toward a drain to investigate.

[City of Surrey: fish and seasonal viewing](#)

[City of Surrey: Tynehead Regional Park](#)

[City of Surrey: water pollution and storm drains](#)

# A usable observation check

Use one or two criteria at a time. Capture a short example, then choose a next teaching move.

- ☐ Describes a specific detail available in the image, description or observation.
- ☐ Separates an observation from an inference or uncertainty.
- ☐ Asks a question that could guide further observation or source-checking.
- ☐ Supports an explanation with a relevant detail; considers another supported explanation.
- ☐ Compares dated views carefully and notices changes in viewpoint or conditions.
- ☐ Contributes through a chosen communication mode and respects others' access, boundaries and ideas.

## Record one piece of evidence

Date / image or observation point: \_\_\_\_\_

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## Use the response to decide what comes next

- If a claim is too broad: ask 'Which detail supports that?' and model a narrower claim.
- If observation and explanation blur: sort two examples into 'I notice' and 'I think because'.
- If ideas differ: compare evidence before asking anyone to revise. Do not require agreement.
- If access blocks the response: adjust the input or communication mode; keep the learning goal.

Do not grade walking distance, species-name recall, handwriting, eye contact or willingness to share personal feelings. A learner can pass on public sharing and still provide evidence privately.

A simple weekly rhythm: notice a new view; explain with evidence; revisit a place; compare; reflect on one idea or feasible care action. Use as much or as little of the journal as the learning calls for.

# Source notes and links

Image credits stay with every photograph in the image bank. Linked titles below open the source.

Ask who made the image, where and when it was made, and what lies outside the frame. An archival image is a comparison resource, not evidence of today's local conditions. The bank records date/location limits; student observations should also record their own dates.

Use local Nation-authored or explicitly shared Indigenous resources with accurate attribution and the relevant permission/protocol. Do not invent an Indigenous story or voice, treat all Nations as one, or ask a student to speak for a Nation. A generic nature observation does not deliver the First Peoples knowledge strand by itself.

Photo permissions: original credits, source links and license labels remain with each image. Images are fitted proportionally and may have been resized or converted for the site/PDF; no subject-content edits are made by this generator. Original licenses remain in force. Check each license before adapting or redistributing an image.

## [BC Science 6](#)

Primary fit: observation, inquiry, evidence, communicating and reflecting on place.

## [BC English Language Arts 6](#)

Interpret visual texts, share perspectives and develop clear explanations.

## [BC Physical and Health Education 6](#)

Optional buddy walk: safe movement, relationships and well-being. Plan appropriate physical activity separately.

## [BC Career Education 6](#)

Optional roles and project: inclusive collaboration, leadership and responsibility.

## [BC Social Studies 6](#)

Optional substantive inquiry into access, resource decisions and informed action.

## [BC Tree Book: bigleaf maple](#)

Compare leaf features with an identified reference.

## [BC Tree Book: Douglas-fir](#)

Compare cone bracts and other tree features.

## [National Park Service: mosses](#)

Mosses in Pacific Northwest forests.

## [National Park Service: lichens](#)

Lichen relationships and characteristics.

## [UBC: mushrooms in fall](#)

Background for teachers; this activity is observation, not foraging.

## [US Forest Service: down wood](#)

Ecological roles of fallen wood and forest-floor material.

## [Surrey: water pollution](#)

Connections between streets, storm drains and waterways.

## [Surrey: fish and salmon viewing](#)

Check seasonal viewing guidance; sightings are not guaranteed.

## [Surrey: Tynehead Regional Park](#)

Starting point for an optional salmon extension; check current conditions and access.

## [Surrey Nature Centre: access and facilities](#)

Check specific surfaces, slopes, seating and facilities for the chosen route.

## [Surrey: outdoor learning resources](#)

Local outdoor learning and stewardship resources.

## [Surrey Schools: Indigenous learning](#)

Use district-curated and Nation-authored sources with attribution and sharing protocols.